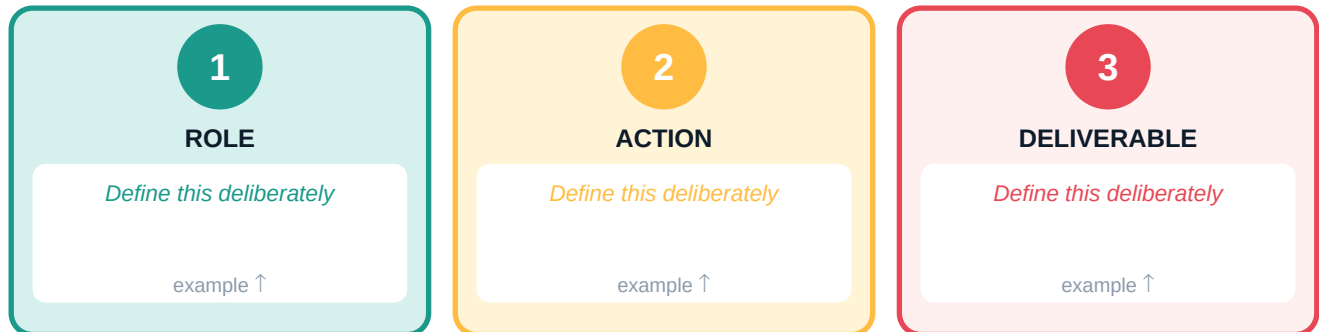


CHAPTER 5

Give AI a Job, Not Just a Question



THE QUESTION VERSUS THE JOB There is a meaningful difference between asking AI a question and giving AI a job.

A question invites a response. A job assigns a task with a clear deliverable, a scope, and implicit quality criteria.

Question: "What do I need to know about redundancy letters?" Job: "You are an HR communications specialist. Draft a redundancy letter for a member of our sales team who has been with the company for three years. The reason is restructuring, not performance. Tone: respectful and clear. The letter must include: confirmation of the decision, notice period (one month), details of the settlement package (to be inserted), available support resources, and the process for appeal. UK employment law applies."

The question gets you information about redundancy letters, a textbook answer pitched at an anonymous reader. The job gets you a document you can actually edit and use.

WHY IT WORKS Role assignment and job framing do not change what AI "knows." They change the frame through which AI selects and structures what it produces. A prompt that says "you are an experienced financial analyst" causes AI to draw more heavily from the patterns associated with financial analysis, more technical vocabulary, more rigorous structure, more appropriate caution. A prompt that specifies a deliverable (a letter, a report, an agenda) constrains the format. Together, role and job framing channel AI's generation toward something more precisely useful.

THE BEFORE -> BETTER -> BEST: GIVING AI A JOB BEFORE (the vague question)

"What should I include in a client proposal?"

What AI produces: A generic list of proposal sections that any business book might contain. Executive summary, scope, timeline, pricing, terms. Correct. Applicable to no one's specific situation.

Why it's weak: AI has no information about the client, the industry, the type of work, the relationship, or what distinguishes this proposal from a hundred others.

BETTER (the specific task)

"Write an outline for a proposal for a digital marketing retainer, targeting a mid-size UK retail company. The agency specialises in SEO and paid social. The prospect has expressed interest but is also talking to two other agencies. The proposal needs to address: our methodology, relevant case studies, pricing structure (monthly retainer, tiered options), and what makes us different."

What AI produces: A structured outline specific to this type of proposal with relevant sections and brief notes on what each should contain.

What improved: AI now has the industry, the type of work, the competitive context, and the key elements to address.

BEST (role + job + context + output specifications)

"You are a senior account director at a boutique UK digital marketing agency. You are writing a proposal for a monthly SEO and paid social retainer for Thornton's, a mid-size UK garden centre chain with 12 locations. The prospect is also

Chapter 5 - Give AI a Job, Not Just a Question

considering two larger agencies. The decision maker is the Marketing Director, who has told us she values transparency and long-term partnerships over flashy pitches.

Write a proposal outline that: leads with their specific situation rather than our credentials; demonstrates understanding of the garden centre sector and its seasonal patterns; presents three pricing tiers (Starter / Growth / Full Service); and ends with a section on how we measure success and report to clients.

Structure: section headings with one-sentence notes on content. Not the full proposal, the outline I will then develop. Max two pages when written up."

What AI produces: A highly specific outline that could only work for this client, this agency, and this competitive context. The structure respects the decision maker's stated values. The pricing presentation is appropriately tiered. The language is right for the relationship.



WHAT CHANGED?



WHAT WAS ADDED WHY IT MATTERED

Role: senior account director Contextualised the voice and level of expertise

Specific client name and Anchored content in a real situation context

Decision maker's stated Shaped the strategic angle of the proposal values

Sector knowledge Prompted sector-relevant thinking requirement

Clear deliverable "Outline I will develop" prevented over- generation

Output constraints Kept length appropriate



PART II - BUILD BETTER INTERACTIONS

CHOOSING THE RIGHT ROLE Role assignment is optional but often valuable. The rule of thumb: assign a role when the task has a domain, a voice, or a level of expertise that you want AI to reflect.

Useful role frames:

Professional identity: "You are an experienced employment solicitor" Expertise level: "You are a secondary school science teacher" Perspective: "You are a sceptical reader encountering this argument for the first time" Function: "You are a copy editor reviewing this draft"

Role frames that don't help much: overly elaborate backstories, fictional identities with no relevance to the task, vague superlatives ("you are the world's greatest expert"). Keep roles grounded in what kind of expertise or perspective would actually be useful for this task.

ASSIGNING A SPECIFIC, ACTIONABLE JOB The instruction "help me with X" is not a job. It is an open invitation that AI will answer with whatever seems most plausibly helpful, which is usually the most generic interpretation of the task.

A job has:

A clear action verb: write, summarise, extract, compare, identify, structure, rewrite, analyse A clear deliverable: a document, a list, a table, a set of questions, a draft A clear scope: this document, these notes, this specific situation

Compare:

Chapter 5 - Give AI a Job, Not Just a Question

"Help me with my CV" -> AI will ask what kind of help or produce something generic "Rewrite the experience section of my CV to emphasise project management and stakeholder communication, using active verbs, targeting senior operations manager roles in the financial services sector" -> AI has a job

TRY THIS WRITE DOWN A TASK YOU REGULARLY DO THAT TAKES MORE THAN AN HOUR. NOW DESCRIBE IT AS A JOB FOR AI

[Role, if relevant]. [Action verb] [specific deliverable] using [source material]. The output should [format/length/tone specifications]. The intended reader is [audience]. Do not [explicit exclusion if needed].

Notice how much this forces you to clarify what you actually want before AI starts.

WATCH OUT ASSIGNING AN EXPERT ROLE DOES NOT MAKE AI'S OUTPUT MORE ACCURATE. IT MAY MAKE IT MORE FLUENTLY



PART II - BUILD BETTER INTERACTIONS